



WATCHING AND WAITING: The Third Front project may gain momentum as the Congress continues to be humiliated

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man—like the rest of us—has no idea whether he will be there at 7 Race Course Road if the party returns to power. He is the most dutiful but, irrespective of what the BJP leader who covets his job thinks of him, the least powerful prime minister. And it is becoming increasingly clear that his middle-class appeal is a bit of an exaggeration. It was, after all, the voters of Bangalore who helped BJP come closer to absolute majority. “Where was the need for the prime minister to lose sleep over the arrest of Dr Hanif in Australia and not over the collapse of Bangalore as a city?” asks a senior industrialist from the city. Urban disillusion can’t be more pointed.

THE THIRD AFFRONT

When a proven loser is at the helm of the coalition, the partners and supporters have every reason to doubt the viability of cohabitation. The Government has started taking blows

from the Left. The first casualty is likely to be the prime minister’s pet project, the Indo-US nuclear deal, which is anyway an undead deal. CPI(M) maintains that Karnataka has been lost as the UPA failed to deliver its promises. “The written intent is there but in spirit, through action and policies, it’s not happening. The CMP is not being followed,” says CPI(M) Politburo member Sitaram Yechury. As demanded by its Left partners, the party will tell the UPA that it is losing patience with the Government’s approach to issues like price rise.

Scarred by the panchayat elections in West Bengal and a divided house in Kerala, CPI(M) may revive the idea of a Third Front. The news from Bangalore, though, has not energised many. The UNPA has already been dented by the Samajwadi Party’s dalliance with the Congress. A resurgent BJP has forced parties like the Telugu Desam, the Indian National Lok Dal and the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) to take a

fresh look at their electoral strategies. AGP is high on the probable list of BJP backers. All three parties have shared power with BJP on different occasions. For them, the Congress still remains the natural enemy.

The next prime minister of India will not be chosen by his or her party alone. Leaders like Mayawati, Chandrababu Naidu, Jayalalithaa, Om Prakash Chautala and Mulayam Singh Yadav will be arbiters. The battle lines of 2009 will get clearer after the verdicts in Delhi, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. Karnataka may be BJP’s gateway to the south, but the highway to Delhi passes through these states and there are many potholes and debris that both the national parties will need to bypass. Only a leader with a strong chariot, a dedicated army and an imaginative slogan can reach the destination. At the moment, that leader is far far away from 10 Janpath.

with Priya Sahgal, Shafi Rahman, Uday Mahurkar and Saurabh Shukla